



Laundry Facilities Use by Mental Health Patients Consumers SOP

Scope

Site	Department, division or operational area	Applicable to
Royal Perth Bentley Group (RPBG)	Mental Health Division Inpatient wards/services	Nursing, Allied Health

Purpose

This standard operational procedure (SOP) guides staff regarding mental health consumers' safe use of laundry facilities.

Links within document

- [Appendix I: Cleaning Schedule – Washing Machine](#)
- [Appendix II: Cleaning Schedule – Clothes Dryer](#)

Background

Washing machines are available in most mental health wards/services (adult and older adult), including Wards 6, 7, 8, F block Occupational Therapy, East Metropolitan Youth Unit (EMyU)/Ward 11, Ward 2K, Ward 10 and Transitional Care Unit (TCU). Washing lines or clothes dryers are available in some wards, e.g. Ward 6.

Consumers are encouraged to take as much responsibility as possible for maintaining activities of daily living (ADLs) as part of their recovery journey during an inpatient stay. Consumers may use laundry facilities if clinically appropriate and under the supervision of a clinician.

The laundry areas may contain fittings and fixtures, isolation from main ward environments, and have associated ligature points or unlocked or open doors, which, under certain circumstances, could pose a potential risk to consumers who are at increased risk of self-harm or whose risk rating is considered highly changeable.

Cleaning of washing machines/dryers following use by consumers is the responsibility of clinician(s).

Best practice processes for cleaning are contained in the **RPBG Linen Management Policy**. This policy is to be read in conjunction with this SOP.

It is mandatory that all staff (including casual staff members) complete personal protective equipment (PPE) training when commencing duties on inpatient wards.

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Endorsed by: Mental Health Service Co-Director 02/08/2024
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Procedure details

Laundry and washing machine areas that are lockable **must remain locked** when not in use and supervised when in use to promote safety within the ward/service.

Use of washing machines/washing line processes

- Consumer suitability for the use of laundry facilities will be based on clinical judgement, risk assessment and integrated notes, as well as their supervision requirements and ward or service milieu.
- Where appropriate, prior to the use of laundry facilities, clinicians are to use a Progressive Risk Assessment (PRA) to document identified risks/changes in a consumer's level of observation/changes in mental state. Clinicians are to document their acceptance/refusal of request to use facilities and the consumer's supervision needs, including formal assessment of ADLs in the consumer's medical record.
- Provide an orientation for the use of the laundry facilities to each consumer.
- Ensure the washing and drying of consumers' personal clothing items meets requirements for dirty/clean/grossly soiled items in accord with the **RPBG Linen Management Policy**, i.e. clean and dirty clothes must be kept separate before and after washing and drying.
- **One nurse** to complete supervision of a consumer if hanging clothes on a washing line
 - Note: A consumer assessed as high risk of self-harm/aggression towards others should not be allowed to hang clothes and alternatives provided (e.g. use of a dryer), as appropriate
 - For TCU, supervision requirements will be assessed on a case by case basis.

Cleaning and maintenance of washing machines/washing lines/clothes dryers

- Maintain cleanliness of the washing machine/washing line/clothes dryer (refer to [Table I: Cleaning Processes of Washing Machines/Clothes Dryers](#)) with use of appropriate PPE and hand hygiene in accordance with the machine specifications e.g. lint filter, dispenser and agitator and complete the relevant cleaning schedules, i.e. [Appendix I: Cleaning Schedule - Washing Machine](#) and [Appendix II: Cleaning Schedule - Clothes Dryer](#).
- The schedules and cleanliness of machines/dryers may be subject to audit as directed by Infection Prevention & Management (IP&M). Nurse Unit Managers or Clinical Nurse Specialists or Clinical Nurse Manager are responsible for ensuring cleaning schedule is maintained.
- Before cleaning ensure that the dryer is disconnected from the power (i.e. unplug the machine from the power socket).
- Check that an annual maintenance safety check by Facilities Management is completed. Refer to **RPBG Linen Management Policy**.

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Procedure details – Cleaning and maintenance of washing machines/clothes dryers cont'd

Table I: Cleaning Processes of Washing Machines/Clothes Dryers

✓ Tick symbol indicates that the task is to apply to the relevant machine

Steps	Cleaning tasks	Front-Loader Washing Machine	Top-loader Washing Machine	Dryer
1	Clean gasket and door seals of machine with neutral detergent and disposable, soft cloth /detergent wipe	✓	✓	Clean the control panel and outer surfaces with detergent wipes/ disposable, soft damp cloth and neutral detergent after every load
2	Fill the drum/dispenser with neutral detergent and run the longest washing cycle at the hottest and largest load settings	✓ Add detergent to the softener and detergent dispensers, and begin the wash cycle	✓ Allow the water to run for a few minutes, then add in detergent Allow the machine to agitate for 1 minute to combine the ingredients, then stop the cycle to let the mixture soak for one hour before allowing the cycle to finish	Clean the inside of the dryer after every load Wipe away/remove any residual dirt / lint / objects and wipe clean with damp cloth and neutral detergent
3	Once the cycle finishes, run a second cycle and repeat Step 2	✓	✓	Clean the lint filter after every load*
4	Clean dispenser filter and outside of washing machine. Scrub the top edges of the tub's rim and all other areas that water can enter	✓	✓ Wipe down the agitator	Remove lint filter and wipe the surfaces with a cloth Ensure filter is fitted correctly back into place before use of dryer
5	Clean filter by removing all debris with water and detergent If the filter is extremely clogged or dirty, soak it in a tub of warm water before scrubbing with soap	✓ Open the access door with a coin/ screwdriver located at front and bottom of the washer and remove the filter	✓ Unscrew the fabric softener dispenser located on top of the agitator (found in the middle of the washing machine) Reach inside to remove the filter	
6	Ensure any water spills onto floor are wiped immediately and use "wet floor" signs if required	✓	✓	✓

*Lint produced in drying cycle can become a fire hazard if allowed to accumulate in or around the dryer.

Procedure details – Cleaning and maintenance of washing machines/clothes dryers cont'd

R PBG staff to use versions of the SSCD that are on PSOLIS or when they become available on PSOLIS. For documents that are not available on PSOLIS, staff must complete the SSCD documents in paper-based or sanctioned writable PDF format. Refer to the **DoH Triage to Discharge Guidelines** for details of which SSCD documents are available on PSOLIS.

Compliance monitoring

- Monthly environment safety audit and random, spot check audits that are reported to ward staff meetings.
- Clinical Incident Management (CIM) system process and/or Combined Hazard or Incident Report (CHoIR) relating to washing machine/clothes dryer incidents/breaches in PPE.
- Compliments/Complaints Management System.

Facilitator

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Laundry Facilities Use in the EMyU: SOP. Revision Date: 05/2021

Washing Line Guideline, Ward 6, BHS. Revision date: 06/2020

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Related policies, practice standards, clinical guidelines

R PBG Policy Hub

- [Progressive Risk Assessment SOP](#)
- [Potentially Harmful Items Management for Mental Health Patients SOP](#)
- [Mental Health Inpatient Triage to Discharge SOP](#)
- [Hand Hygiene Policy](#)
- [R PBG Linen Management Policy](#)

EMHS Policy Hub

- [Infection Prevention and Management Policy](#)
- [Rights of Patients in Mental Health Services Policy](#)

Department of Health Policy Hub

- [Statewide Standardised Clinical Documentation \(SSCD\) for Mental Health Services Policy](#)
- [Triage to Discharge, Mental Health Framework for SSCD](#)

Other

- [Charter of Mental Health Care Principles \(MHA 2014\)](#)
- [Mental Health Act 2014](#)
- [Work Health and Safety Act 2020](#)

Legislative requirements, the evidence and the standard

For information relating to the legislative requirements and standards that R PBG policy documents must adhere to, and regarding the logos and levels of evidence used within R PBG policy documents, refer to [Legislative Requirements, the Evidence and the Standard](#) (live link) on the Policy HUB.

ACSQHC NSQHS Standards 2nd Edition (2021):

Standard 1: Clinical Governance

Standard 2: Partnering with Consumers

Standard 3: Preventing and Controlling Infections

NSMHS Standards (2010):

Standard 2: Safety

Standard 3: Partnering with Consumers

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Appendix I: Cleaning Schedule – Washing Machine

Refer to the Laundry Facilities Use by Mental Health Consumers SOP for information on how to clean the washing machines.

*Cleaning to be completed once a week and cleaning schedule is to be placed on/near the washing machine

****Indicate Yes (Y) / No (N) as applicable**

Date	Time	Bowl and outside cleaned Y/N	Dispenser cleaned Y/N	Filter cleaned Y/N	Cleaning cycle completed Y/N	Name of staff	Signature of staff	Comments

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Appendix II: Cleaning Schedule – Clothes Dryer

Refer to the **Laundry Facilities Use by Mental Health Consumers SOP** and **Manufacturers Guidelines** for information on how to clean the dryer

*Cleaning to be completed once a week (when dryer is in use) and cleaning schedule is to be placed on/near the dryer

****Indicate Yes (Y) / No (N) as applicable**

Date	Time	Bowl and outside cleaned Y/N	Inside of dryer cleaned Y/N	Lint filter cleaned Y/N	Name of staff	Signature of staff	Comments

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